

reforms to voters. And failed. As Chidambaram and Prime Minister Manmohan Singh know all too well from personal experience. Voters perceive reforms as pro-rich, perhaps because it is the educated, the skilled and the affluent who are best poised to grab the benefits. The pro-reforms finance minister was the least expected votary of vote bank politics, but on February 29, he did the impossible. He balanced politics with economics. As he told INDIA TODAY, "I've come around to the view that while we should keep the growth story intact, it will endure in value only if you include people who have been left out."

Shetkari Sanghatana leader and farmer Sharad Joshi put it succinctly when he exclaimed to a TV audience, "UPA has bowled a googly for which the Opposition has no answer." True, the Opposition did have an inkling about the loan waiver—how could they not, with groups of farmers suddenly featuring on 10 Janpath's social diary and hoardings all over Lutyens' Delhi, thanking Congress President Sonia Gandhi even before the Budget announcement—but no one was prepared for the scale of the gesture.

Caught off guard, NDA jumped to its feet in protest when Chidambaram made his announcement. It was bad semantics. Leaders later hastened to explain that they were not against the waiver but were questioning the delivery mechanism. As an exuberant Sonia called it a "historic and revolutionary step", former finance minister Yashwant Sinha cited the loan waiver of the V.P. Singh government and declared that "populism never pays". To get a perspective of the size, consider this: the biggest loan waiver till date was the Rs 10,000-crore scheme announced by the V.P. Singh government. The value of that waiver today would be Rs 31,801.24 crore, after indexing for inflation. UPA's offering is twice as big as the biggest by any socialist government.



“The budget is pure economics. Spending on education, health, women and minorities is good economics, for all of them become more productive.”

P. CHIDAMBARAM, FINANCE MINISTER

Of course, when the stakes are high, it isn't long before the claim game begins. The Congress had the first mover advantage. On Budget day, there was a well-choreographed 'spontaneous' surge of farmers to 10 Janpath, led by Haryana's chief minister's son Deepinder Singh Hooda, who came driving a tractor. An MBA graduate from the US, he is clearly well-versed in the fine art of brand identity. Manmohan and heir apparent Rahul Gandhi joined Sonia in playing gracious host to a potential votebank. Keen not to be left out of the credit race, the PMO added its own spin, sending out SMSes to a few chosen numbers, saying that for two years Manmohan had been pointing out that "the British had started the tradition of a farm loan waiver every 20 years. The prime minister had been saying it's time we

did it. And now he has."

Even as Congress general secretaries were asked to maintain a steady parade of farmers to 10 Janpath, NCP choreographed an ad campaign in national dailies and hoardings across Maharashtra, thanking chief Sharad Pawar for "promises fulfilled". Normally elusive, Pawar took guard for a much-needed image correction: "I have been accused of concentrating only on cricket, but I have now shown that I also care for agriculture." Even the Opposition had tired of calling him the minister for BCCI. Railways Minister Lalu Prasad, who had been ranting about the lack of sensitivity within the Congress towards the poor, told visitors from Bihar, "Yeh ham sab ka Budget hai (this is everyone's Budget)".

BJP, however, did not miss the opportunity to state the fact that UPA did



AMIT MITRA, SECRETARY-GENERAL, FICCI

“The finance minister did not lower the corporate tax rate. Instead, he took the indirect route to stimulate demand.”